

The Matra dispute

Two disputes thirteen years apart, usually told as one — the test-track fires an engineering change explains, the seventeen-year lawsuit Matra won, and the walkout that taught Taipei how to buy its next railway.

Taiwan's first metro line was bought as a French turnkey system in 1988, caught fire twice on the test track in 1993, opened in 1996 more than four years late, and lost its builder's maintenance staff not long afterwards^[6]. Seventeen years after the signing, the Supreme Court ordered Taipei to pay Matra roughly **NT\$1.64 billion**, and the city paid^[1].

Almost all tellings run this together into one story about a French company storming off. It is two stories, thirteen years apart, and telling them apart is the point of this page.

BR WENHU LINE 文湖線			
CLIENT DORTS, Taipei City Government ^[1]	CONTRACTOR Matra Transport ^[1]	CONTRACT SIGNED 13 July 1988 ^[6]	CONTRACT VALUE ≈ NT\$7.87 billion ^[6]
LINE OPENED 28 March 1996 ^[9]	ARBITRATION AWARD 6 October 1993 ^[1]	FINAL JUDGMENT 22 July 2005 ^[1]	THE CITY PAID ≈ NT\$1.64 billion ^[1]

Two disputes, not one

The delay claim, 1988–2005.

Matra sued for the cost of a contract that ran years longer than it was written for, because the civil works its equipment depended on were late — the claim arises, in 自由時報's words, 「因土木工程部分包商施工延誤，連帶造成馬特拉的工期延長，增加成本費用」^[1]. This is the dispute that went to arbitration in 1993 and was still before the Supreme Court in 2005^[1]. It is about money and contract law, and **Matra won it**^[1].

The withdrawal, 1996–97.

After the line opened, Matra pulled its technical staff out of Taiwan and stopped maintaining the system^[7]. This is the dispute everybody remembers — the one that produced the most famous sentence said about the Taipei Metro `[/rail/operators/trtc/]`, and the one that steered the procurement that followed.

They are connected: the withdrawal happened because the delay claim had poisoned the relationship. But they are not the same event, and the NT\$1.64 billion that circulates belongs to the first, not the second^[1].

The contract

The fires, and the engineering behind them

The arbitration, and seventeen years of litigation

The withdrawal, and the year nobody can pin down



Keeping a metro nobody would maintain



The political ledger



What it changed: buying the Neihu extension



What is not established



References

3 of 13 sources on this page are primary — published by the operator, the builder or government.

- 1** Muzha metro line: Matra wins, Taipei to pay NT\$1.64 billion [<https://www.epochtimes.com/b5/5/7/23/n995027.htm>]
木柵捷運線 馬特拉勝訴 北市要賠16.4億
SECONDARY 孫友廉 , 陳曉宜 , 鄭學庸 , 自由時報 , 23 July 2005 (via 大紀元 reprint)
accessed 2026-08-06
archived [<https://web.archive.org/web/20260807043739/https://www.epochtimes.com/b5/5/7/23/n995027.htm>]

The contemporaneous report of the final judgment, with the figures, the procedural stages and the limitation-period reasoning, plus a signed commentary. The best source this page has for the litigation. The original 自由時報 URL has rotted; the 大紀元 reprint is what remains reachable.

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- 2 Cars altered, trains burned — and Matra paid NT\$1.6 billion anyway [<https://news.ltn.com.tw/news/life/paper/258078>]

改車廂火燒車 還賠馬特拉16億

SECONDARY 洪敏隆 , 劉榮 , 自由時報 , 14 November 2008 accessed 2026-08-06

archived [<https://web.archive.org/web/20260807043814/https://news.ltn.com.tw/news/life/paper/258078>]

Found while preparing this page, and load-bearing: an account of the fire mechanism — two-car units run as four in Taipei, brakes locking on one axle pair while another drove on, tyres overheating — that is independent of and three years earlier than 黃令名's. Two tellings, one mechanism.

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- 3 How the Taipei Metro became a 'jury-rigged metro': technological hybridity and the birth of the system [<https://twstreetcorner.org/2021/04/06/台北捷運如何成為「拼裝捷運」？科技混生性與北捷/>]

台北捷運如何成為「拼裝捷運」？科技混生性與北捷的誕生

SECONDARY 黃令名 , 巷仔口社會學 (Streetcorner Sociology), 6 April 2021

accessed 2026-08-06

archived [<https://web.archive.org/web/20260807043954/https://twstreetcorner.org/2021/04/06/%E5%8F%B0%E5%8C%97%E6%8D%B7%E9%81%8B%E5%A6%82%E4%BD%95%E6%88%90%E7%82%BA%E3%80%8C%E6%8B%BC%E8%A3%9D%E6%8D%B7%E9%81%8B%E3%80%8D%E5%BC%9F%E7%A7%91%E6%8A%80%E6%B7%B7%E7%94%9F%E6%80%A7%E8%88%87%E5%8C%97/>]

A sociologist of technology writing from his own doctoral research — still the most valuable single account of these events in any language. Not neutral, and does not claim to be: the framing is a thesis about technological dependence. Also republished by The News Lens.

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- 4 Without Matra, we pulled it ourselves — thirty years of the Taipei Metro [<http://www.mirrormedia.mg/story/20260305cu1002>]

名家現場／沒有馬特拉，我們自己拉—北捷三十年

PRIMARY 陳水扁 , 鏡週刊 , 11 March 2026 accessed 2026-08-06

archived [<https://web.archive.org/web/20260806043259/https://www.mirrormedia.mg/story/20260305cu1002>]

The man who said it, on the record thirty years later. Primary for the quotation and for his own account of the parts-pricing fight behind it — and read with the caution any memoir earns: it is the speaker's version, published on an anniversary.

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- 5 Linguang station [<https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/麟光站>]

麟光站

SECONDARY 維基百科 (Chinese Wikipedia) accessed 2026-08-07

The station chronology that dates both 1993 fires and, decisively, numbers the second: 「1993年5月5日：辛亥站前發生火燒車事件」 and 「1993年9月24日：發生第二次火燒車事件」. 〈木柵線〉 carries the May incident but not the September one, which is why an earlier pass on this page could not confirm the second date.

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- 6 Muzha Line [<https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/木柵線>]

木柵線

SECONDARY 維基百科 (Chinese Wikipedia) accessed 2026-08-06

archived [https://web.archive.org/web/20250531163800/https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/木柵線]

The fullest chronology of the construction years — contract dates, the fires, the suspensions, the inspections. It also contradicts itself on the year Matra withdrew, which this page publishes as the disagreement it is.

7 Wenhu line [https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/文湖線]

文湖線

SECONDARY 維基百科 (Chinese Wikipedia) accessed 2026-08-06

archived [https://web.archive.org/web/20250714045049/https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/文湖線]

Carries the 1997 reading of the withdrawal — 馬特拉與台北市政府捷運工程局發生合約糾紛後，將技術人員全數撤離。

8 The Taipei Metro's Matra feud [https://www.businessweekly.com.tw/Archive/Article?StrId=1967]

台北捷運的「馬特拉」恩怨情仇

SECONDARY 古文全，商業周刊 445, 30 May 1996 accessed 2026-08-06

archived [https://web.archive.org/web/20260807044117/https://www.businessweekly.com.tw/Archive/Article?StrId=1967]

Written six weeks after the line opened — the closest thing to a contemporaneous account of the relationship breaking down. Paywalled beyond its opening, and not read past it here; cited only for what its date and title establish.

9 Wenshan—Neihu Line [https://www.dorts.gov.taipei/cp.aspx?n=DBAC040496EFAB94]

文山內湖線

PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Rapid Transit Systems (DORTS)

accessed 2026-08-07

archived [https://web.archive.org/web/20260209210832/https://www.dorts.gov.taipei/cp.aspx?n=DBAC040496EFAB94]

The builder's own project record — section lengths, opening dates, and its own classification of the testing-phase incident: 「木柵線於82年系統測試階段發生輪胎起火意外事故」。It says nothing at all about the dispute, which is itself informative; and it names Matra nowhere.

10 Siemens increases its stake in MATRA Transport International [https://www.lagardere.com/en/press-release/siemens-increases-its-stake-in-matra-transport-international/]

PRIMARY Lagardère (press release, 1 October 1998) accessed 2026-08-06

archived [https://web.archive.org/web/20260806042121/https://www.lagardere.com/en/press-release/siemens-increases-its-stake-in-matra-transport-international/]

Matra's own parent announcing the sale of the transport business to Siemens.

11 Matra Transport changes its name [https://www.metro-magazine.com/news/matra-transport-changes-its-name]

SECONDARY Metro Magazine accessed 2026-08-06

archived [https://web.archive.org/web/20260807044158/https://www.metro-magazine.com/news/matra-transport-changes-its-name]

Trade press reporting Siemens completing to 100% and the rename to Siemens Transportation Systems in November 2001.

- 12** Taipei Metro VAL256 electric multiple unit [<https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/台北捷運VAL256型電聯車>]

台北捷運VAL256型電聯車

SECONDARY 維基百科 (Chinese Wikipedia) accessed 2026-08-06

archived [<https://web.archive.org/web/20221006051618/https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/台北捷運VAL256型電聯車>]

- 13** Bombardier INNOVIA APM 256 electric multiple unit [https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/龐巴迪INNOVIA_APM_256型電聯車]

龐巴迪INNOVIA APM 256型電聯車

SECONDARY 維基百科 (Chinese Wikipedia) accessed 2026-08-06

archived [https://web.archive.org/web/20150531215555/https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/龐巴迪INNOVIA_APM_256型電聯車]

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Station names, codes and sequence from TDX Transport Data eXchange, Ministry of Transportation and Communications, operators TRTC, NTMC, and TYMC. Government open data. Retrieved 2026-08-10; source last updated 2020-01-31. The 12 Sanying station records absent from TDX are sourced directly to New Taipei Metro and government publications on their pages. Provenance.